



Rewind

A Time Travel TTRPG

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Introduction

What is Rewind?

Rewind is an episodic sci-fi time travel tabletop role-playing game (TTRPG). You, as a time-traveling character, solve historical mysteries and prevent paradoxes one mission at a time.

Time Travel & You

It is the year 20xx (current year + nine years). Nine years ago, the first known instance of time travel was recorded by Letitia Knox, an independent inventor. Knox disappeared shortly thereafter, and nobody really knows what happened. But she left behind schematics for her groundbreaking invention; the Knox Engine, a spatially- and temporally-transient machine, was iterated on by every research university, government, and corporation.

In the years since, time travel has expanded—with limitations. Everyone *could* do it, given enough money and resources, but it's dangerous even for experts. Incorrect coordinates could cause a Knox Engine to transport its travelers somewhere random in time, or even out of time altogether. An incautious hobbyist or tourist might cause a paradox, open up a hole in the very fabric of time, and get pulled into the void. It's a risky pursuit.

You, though, are trained in time travel. You work for a university known as LRU (Large Research University) in the Department of Temporal Research. You might be a professor, a technician, a student, or anyone else hired by the school. Yes, anyone—LRU has trained lots of people in time travel, including security guards, librarians, janitors, and more.

Your job, along with your team, is to investigate oddities in time. Sometimes that means tackling an unsolved mystery; other times, it means chasing down a paradox and fixing it before the resulting hole in time becomes disastrous. You are all experts in one field or another, and you've been properly trained for time travel. Your means may be haphazard, and your backgrounds unconventional, but you've got the best interests of time at heart and the resources of LRU at your disposal.



How do rolls & ability checks work in this game?

When your character does something complicated—or attempts anything where success isn't guaranteed—you will have to roll one or more dice. Normally, you will roll one twenty-sided die (abbreviated as 1d20). To succeed, you must roll *at or under* the number of the **ability** you are using. That means it's good to roll low! And it also means that the better you are at something, the higher your score is, and thus the easier it is to succeed.

Advantage and Disadvantage

If your character has a particular **eccentricity** or **expertise** (addressed later in character creation) that applies to the situation, your Game Master will grant you **advantage** on the roll. In that case, roll with 2d20 and take the *lower* of the two dice as your roll. Advantage makes it easier to succeed on your roll.

On the other hand, if a situation is particularly difficult/tricky or your character is *really* exerting themselves to accomplish something, your Game Master may ask you to roll with **disadvantage**. In that case, roll 2d20 and take the *higher* of the two dice as your roll. Disadvantage makes it harder to succeed on your roll.

Abilities, **eccentricities**, and **expertise** will all be addressed later in character creation, and all of them will have an impact on your rolls during the game.



Creating Your Character

Abilities

Your character has five core **abilities**, scores from 3-18, that determine how proficient they are at broad/basic things: Brawn, Agility, Wits, Charm, and Aware. The higher the score, the better your character is at that particular ability.

The first step in creating your character is to roll for their abilities. You have two options here, with varying degrees of randomness.

Score Array:

If you want a character that is guaranteed to be balanced, you may assign your character the following five scores: **7, 9, 10, 11, 13**. You may assign these in any order you like, to whichever ability you like, but you may only use each score once.

Random Rolls:

Alternatively, you may choose to roll for your attributes. If you choose to roll, you will roll five times and assign those scores as you like (same rules apply, you must only use each score once).

Each time, roll 3d20 and take the middle number (the median) as your score. If the median is 1, 2, 19, or 20, re-roll all three dice and take the new median/middle number (keep re-rolling until the median is not 1, 2, 19, or 20).



Say you roll 3d20 and get a 13, 2, and 7. The median number is 7, so you'll write down 7 for one of your ability scores.

Write down those five numbers and assign them to whichever abilities you'd like! Think about what your character might be good or bad at.



Sturdy:

Sturdy is a special ability that you will only use in combat. It represents how well you withstand getting hit (the higher the number, the more resilient you are). Roll 3d20, re-rolling if you get a 1, 2, 19, or 20. Assign the median number to your Sturdy, found in the header of your character sheet.



Eccentricities

Eccentricities are extra-specific, not-often-applicable things that your character is oddly good at. When you attempt to do something that aligns with one of your character's eccentricities, you roll with **advantage**.

To choose eccentricities, you can either pick (in which case you will **pick two eccentricities** from the list on the next page) or **roll 1d100 five times** and pick three of the corresponding eccentricities to keep. If you pick, you get two eccentricities; if you roll, you get three.

What is advantage, again?

If you have advantage on a roll, that means you roll 2d20 (rather than the usual 1d20) and take the *lower* of the two dice. Advantage makes it easier to succeed on your roll.



Eccentricities

d100	Eccentricity
1	Acrobatics
2	Acting
3	Administration
4	Animal Whispering
5	Archery
6	Baking
7	Baseball
8	Basket Weaving
9	Calligraphy
10	Camping
11	Car Mechanics
12	Card-Counting/Gaming
13	Carpentry
14	Climbing
15	Clockmaking
16	Clowning
17	Cocktail Mixing
18	Computer Hacking
19	Contortion
20	Cooking
21	Crocheting
22	Dancing
23	Darts
24	Decoding/Ciphers
25	Drinking
26	Eidetic memory
27	Embroidery
28	Explosives
29	Farming
30	Filmmaking
31	Fire Starting

d100	Eccentricity
32	Firearms
33	Fishing
34	Flower Arranging
35	Foraging
36	Forgery
37	Game Design
38	Gardening
39	Ghost Hunting
40	Glassblowing
41	Gymnastics
42	Hairdressing
43	Hand-to-Hand Combat
44	Helicopter/Plane Piloting
45	Hospitality
46	Hunting
47	Improv Comedy
48	Instrument Making
49	Jewelry Making
50	Jigsaw Puzzle Solving
51	Jousting
52	Key Copying
53	Knife Throwing
54	Knitting
55	Leatherworking
56	Lip Reading
57	Lockpicking
58	Logic Puzzles
59	Magic Tricks
60	Makeup
61	Marathon Running
62	Medicine

d100	Eccentricity
63	Metalworking
64	Millinery (Hat Making)
65	Musical Composition
66	Musical Performance
67	Nature & Wilderness
68	Networking
69	Origami
70	Painting
71	Photography
72	Pickpocketing
73	Pocketknife Tricks
74	Poisons
75	Pottery
76	Sculpture
77	Sewing
78	Ship Piloting
79	Skating
80	Sketching/Drawing
81	Soccer

d100	Eccentricity
82	Spear Fishing
83	Speed Reading
84	Spotless Cleaning
85	Sprinting
86	Stamp Carving
87	Stunt Driving
88	Swimming
89	Swordsmanship
90	Thievery
91	Tinkering
92	Unicycling
93	Video Gaming
94	Voice Throwing
95	Walking on your hands
96	Water Polo
97	Weightlifting
98	Whistling
99	Whitewater Rafting
100	Whittling

How do I roll a d100?

Rolling a d100 really means rolling two dice: one to determine the tens place, and one for the ones place. You'll need two 10-sided dice (2d10). Ideally, you'd use one that has 0-9 on it, and one that has 00-90 on it, but any 2d10 will work.

Roll 1d10 for the tens place and 1d10 for the ones place.

Then combine the numbers! For instance, if you roll a 2 (or 20) for the tens place and a 7 for the ones place, that's a 27. If you roll a 00 for the tens place and a 0 for the ones place, that's a 100.

Expertise

Everyone has some sort of historical expertise—something that your character is particularly knowledgeable about. They might have become an expert through years of study at LRU, it might be a separate hobby that they're knowledgeable about, or they could've acquired their expertise in some other way. Pick which area of history your character is most knowledgeable about, and note it down under expertise.

If you want to build a completely random character, roll 1d12 and take the corresponding expertise (Architecture is #1, and so on down the list). Re-roll if you roll a 12.

Areas of Historical Expertise:

Architecture:

Your character understands the layout of historical buildings and cities, and has extensive knowledge of historical architectural design.

Art:

Your character is a historical art expert and is good at art themselves. They understand historical styles and can often replicate them.

Criminology:

Your character understands historical forensic procedure and is an expert at on-the-scene investigation no matter the time period.

Fashion:

Your character is knowledgeable about all things historical fashion, and is always dressed for the occasion. They're especially good at sewing and mending, and even makeup when necessary.

Language:

Your character has an extensive knowledge of historical forms of language. They can read nearly any common historical language in front of them, and can write in common historical languages.

Nature:

Your character is particularly in tune with nature, and is knowledgeable about medicinal herbs, dangerous plants, and more. When lost in the wilderness, they can usually find a landmark or some way to get out.

Politics:

Your character has an understanding of historical political systems and bureaucracy. They can blend into politically delicate settings, and they understand the local laws/government.

Religion:

Your character has an extensive knowledge of every major religion (and most minor ones, too). They understand customs, rituals, rules, and how to avoid looking like a heretic.

Technology:

Your character has extensive knowledge about historical technologies. They can fix/tinker with old tech, and they understand the inner workings of many historical inventions.

Warfare:

Your character is an expert at historical warfare tactics. This has more to do with strategy and historical battles/wars than with exact weaponry.

Weaponry:

Your character is an expert at historical weaponry. They have extensive knowledge about (and a fair amount of training with) numerous historical weapons.

Gear

Your gear will depend on your expertise. All of your gear is assumed to be carried with you, and accessible to you at all times, unless you explicitly leave it somewhere during a mission.

In addition to your expertise-specific gear, everyone has an **in-ear communication device** whose communication radius is ~1 mile, and will translate most spoken (not written) language. This is how you are able to speak with and understand people from other eras/places. You also have a **modern phone** that can take photos and record video/audio (and has a calculator, compass, etc). Cell phone service will not work in most historical periods, though.

See the next page for your expertise-specific gear.

Expertise-Specific Gear:**Architecture:**

- A set of measuring tools (ruler, protractor, etc) and pencils, and a sketchbook
- Basic historical map of the nearest town/city

Art:

- A set of paintbrushes and small tubes of paint
- A set of period-appropriate pencils and pens, and a sketchbook

Criminology:

- A fingerprint dusting kit
- Many, many ziploc baggies for evidence collecting
- A magnifying glass and flashlight

Fashion:

- A spare set of clothing appropriate for the period (this will change by mission)
- A small sewing kit with two needles, thread, sewing scissors, and pins
- A small makeup kit

Language:

- A pocket dictionary for a period/place-appropriate language
- Period-appropriate writing tools and a scroll of paper

Nature:

- A bag of medicinal and poisonous herbs, berries, etc
- A small set of garden shears

Politics:

- A period/place-appropriate signet ring or other identification (check with your GM)
- A short note of introduction from a relevant political figure (forged, of course)

Religion:

- A small collection of period-appropriate religious trinkets
- A period-appropriate religious book of your choosing

Technology:

- A small recording/listening device (about the size of a quarter, one inch thick) that syncs to your phone within ~1 mile
- A wristwatch that can remotely communicate with your time travel capsule

Warfare:

- A period-appropriate mid- or high-ranking officer's uniform/badge
- A period-appropriate weapon of your choice, non-ranged (sword, knife, etc)

Weaponry:

- A period-appropriate weapon of your choice (set of daggers, gun/pistol, bow, sword, etc)
- A small bag of ammunition for historical ranged weapons



Finishing Touches

Now that you've selected your character's mechanical abilities, it's time to flesh them out. Give your character a **name**, **age**, and **pronouns**. Your character will start healthy (no wounds).

Decide: what is your character's **position** at LRU? Are they a tenured professor, a lecturer, a student, a security guard, a janitor, a librarian, administrative staff, or something else? If you're wondering whether or not the position you've picked is appropriate for the setting, 1) it probably is, you are encouraged to pick an unusual position! And 2) check with your GM.

And finally, give your character a **background**! Jot down a few sentences about who they are, where they came from, and what their goals are.

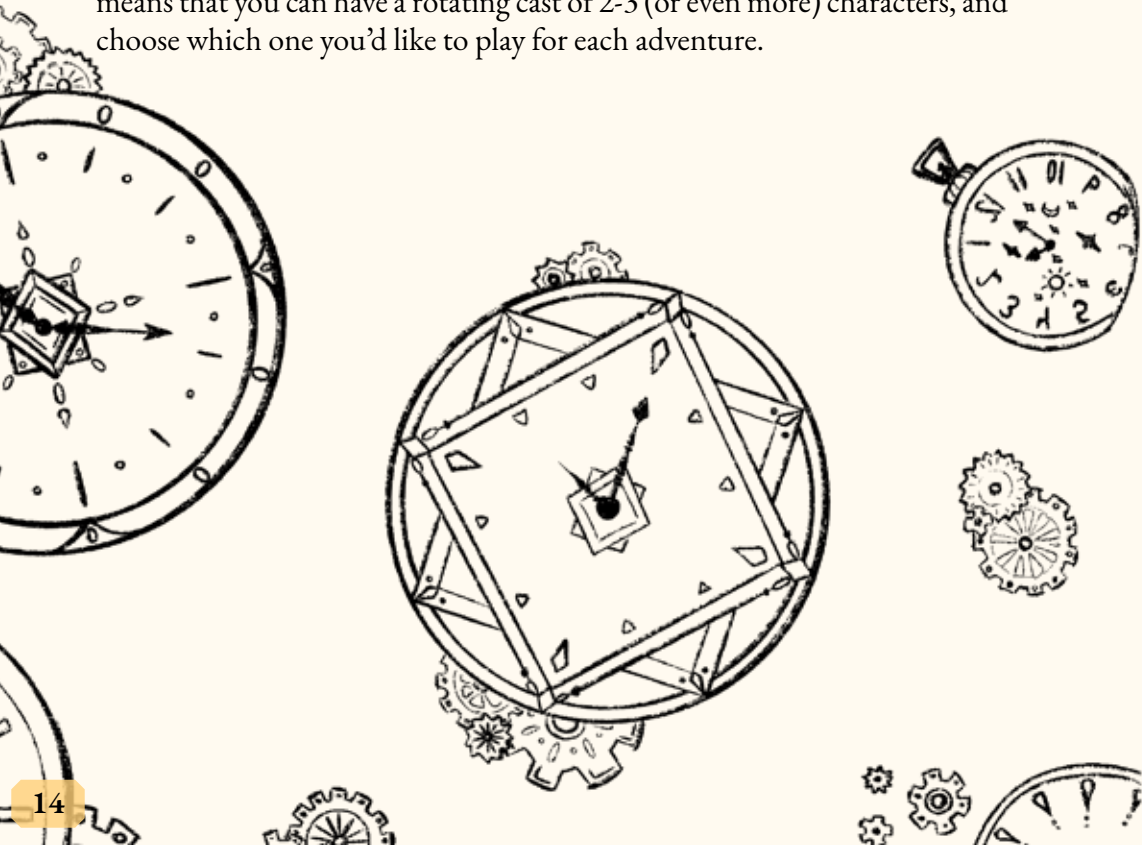
If you are having trouble figuring out your background or want to create a completely random character, you can roll for your background! Use the tables in the **appendix** to randomly pick a few key traits and facts about your character. You can also use these tables for inspiration.

Remember, you don't have to choose from the random table options in the appendix. If you have an idea for a fun occupation, background, or anything else, go with it! You can roll for a background, pick from the appendix tables, or choose something completely different.

There is one exception to this: if you want to create a character who comes from a historical time period, ask your Game Master (GM) first.

Creating Multiple Characters

Though characters don't level up in *Rewind*, you are encouraged to develop and change your character as you play. In addition to developing your starting character's backstory and personality, you may find that you want to play more than one character. That is great! The episodic nature of *Rewind* means that you can have a rotating cast of 2-3 (or even more) characters, and choose which one you'd like to play for each adventure.



Combat & Wounds

Rolling Initiative

Occasionally, your party might end up in a fight, known as **combat**. When that happens, your Game Master (GM) will need to determine who will act in what order. To do that, you will roll **initiative**.

Each player will roll a d20. The player with the highest roll goes first, and so on down the list. If two players tie, the one with the higher agility score goes first (and if they have the same agility score, then they may choose who acts first).

Example:

Milan rolls a 18, and Evie rolls a 13. Milan goes first. But Katie rolled an 18, too. Since Katie's agility score is higher than Milan, Katie will go before Milan.

The GM also rolls initiative for NPCs (non-player characters) involved in combat. These characters are added to the turn order according to their initiative rolls.



INITIATIVE	
1. Katie	(18)
2. Milan	(18)
3. NPC #1	(14)
4. Evie	(13)
5. NPC #2	(7)
6. NPC #3	(1)



Initiative rolls only last the duration of the combat. Once you exit combat, as determined by your GM (or when there is simply nobody left to fight), your initiative scores no longer apply. You may act in any order you choose outside of combat. If you find yourselves in another fight, you will roll initiative again and use that score to determine turn order—as in other TTRPG systems, your turn order is not static across multiple different combats/encounters.

Combat & Turns

After your turn order is determined, you will proceed to combat. Each turn, you may take an **action** and **movement**. You may also talk on your turn. If you are talking in order to persuade/deceive/otherwise influence someone, and you will need to roll to determine your success, that counts as your action for that turn. Other talking (communicating information, planning, trash talking, etc) is free, and can be done at any time.

Actions:

Your action can either be a ranged/close-combat attack, or an interaction of some other sort within the space. You could try to restrain an opponent, for instance, or steal something, or grab a weapon. If you have to roll for it, it's probably an action (with the exception of jumping/climbing; see movement).

Movement:

In one turn, you may move up to 10 feet in any direction (that includes up and down, but you may have to make an Agility check to climb or jump). If you want to move more than 10 feet in your turn, **you may use your action to move another 10 feet**.

Example: Taking a Turn in Combat

Katie's character, Sciona, takes a turn on her initiative. Sciona tries to pick the lock on a door she needs to get through, so Katie rolls for Agility. Her roll fails, so she can't pick the lock. Then, Sciona uses her movement to dart a few feet away to hide behind a bookcase.



Attacking

To attack an opponent, roll for the appropriate ability (usually Brawn for close combat, and Agility for ranged combat). If you succeed, you hit your opponent. If you fail, you miss. Simple as that!

If you hit, though, your opponent has the chance to withstand/minimize the hit. They will roll for **Sturdy**. If they fail their Sturdy roll, they take the appropriate wound level for your attack (see “**Wounds**”). If they succeed, they don’t take a wound. Regardless of whether they succeed or fail, their movement on their next turn is halved. If they are hit a second time before their next turn, they will take disadvantage if they attack on their next turn. They will not take disadvantage on any non-attack action they choose to do.

This works in reverse, too. If you are targeted by another character, they will roll to hit. If they succeed, you’ll have to roll under your own Sturdy to withstand/minimize the hit. If you succeed on your Sturdy roll, you don’t take any wounds. If you fail, you take the appropriate wound level. Regardless of your Sturdy roll, your movement is halved (and, if hit more than once before your next turn, you take disadvantage if you attack on your next turn).

Level of Damage:

Hand-to-hand combat will always deal **Scrape** wounds, unless you are intentionally doing something (choking, gouging out eyes, etc) that would deal **Severe** damage. Blades will do **Slash** damage by default, unless you are intentionally going for the kill. Firearms will always do **Severe** damage. See “**Wounds**” for more information on damage.

Accidental Mishaps:

When you wound someone (or something), **roll 1d20**. If you roll a nat 1, you deal a level of damage one higher than intended. If the intended level of damage was Severe, the target *immediately* dies. There is no saving them. *Only player characters (PCs) roll for Accidental Mishaps when they attack. Non-player characters (NPCs) do not.*



Example: Attacking

Evie's character tries to attack an NPC (non-player character) with a dagger. Evie rolls for **Agility** to hit the NPC, and succeeds. The NPC then rolls for **Sturdy**, but fails. They take a Slash wound (see "Wounds"), if they haven't already, and their movement on their next turn is halved. Evie also has to roll 1d20 for an **Accidental Mishap**. They roll a 5, so nothing happens.

On the NPC's next turn, they try to attack Evie's character with a sword. The GM rolls to see if the NPC will hit. They succeed, but Evie's Sturdy roll also succeeds. Evie's movement is halved on their next turn, but they don't take a wound—they successfully withstood the hit.

Wounds

It's important to note here that combat is dangerous, and shouldn't happen too often. Most (if not all) of your characters are not meant to withstand combat for long.

You only have three **wound levels**: **Scrape**, **Slash**, and **Severe**. Each wound level represents a different intensity/severity of attack. When you are hit (or hit someone in battle), the level of wound that you/they will take depends on the kind of weapon used. You cannot take the same wound level more than once—so if you are punched repeatedly, for instance, you will only take a scrape wound level once, though the other negative effects of getting hit (reduced movement and disadvantage) still apply.



Scrape:

Take this wound level when you are punched, slapped, kicked, or otherwise injured in hand-to-hand combat, or if you take a short/medium fall, faceplant, etc. This is a minor wound. You're beat up, but still very able to fight back or flee.

Slash:

Take this wound level when you are stabbed, cut, or otherwise injured by a sharp object or blunt weapon. Think knives, daggers, swords, hammers, etc. This is a medium-intensity wound. It's bad, but it would take a more lethal hit or a worse attack to seriously injure you.

Severe:

Take this wound level when you are seriously, near-fatally or fatally injured. Think explosions, a blade stabbed directly through your ribcage, a gunshot, etc. Something that, if left untreated, would lead pretty quickly to death. When severely injured, you must **lean on an object or person for stability** and **every check is made with disadvantage** (not just your attacks).

Adrenaline

If you take a Severe wound, you are near death—but still on your feet for just a little longer. Adrenaline propels you into one last furious turn, which you take **immediately** upon becoming severely injured. You may take an action and movement, and any checks you make during your adrenaline-fueled turn are made with **advantage**. Afterwards, you collapse. See the **Severe** wound section and **Critical Condition** for more information on what occurs after being severely injured.

Critical Condition & Stabilization

If you are injured again after getting a **Severe** wound, and that injury is of **Slash** wound level or higher, you enter **Critical Condition**. You lose consciousness and are moments away from death. This also happens if you spend **more than 3 turns (or one minute of non-combat time)** at **Severe** without treatment. If you enter Critical Condition, you have 3 turns,

or one minute in non-combat situations, before you die. Yes, that means permanent death. You can, however, be **stabilized** in order to stave off death a little longer.

Stabilizing:

Your team (any player character or non-player character) can attempt to stabilize your condition before you die. To do this, they must acquire or use medical tools. If they have a modern first aid kit with them, they will roll with **advantage**. Otherwise, improvised medical aid can suffice. To stabilize someone, roll a **raw luck check** (10 and under succeeds, 11 and over fails). If you fail, one other person may attempt the check before the critically injured person dies.

If you succeed, your patient is stabilized and will live up to three more hours. They'll still need hospital care, but will be fine for the time being. However, a stabilized character **remains Severely wounded**. If they take another wound of Slash or higher, they return to critical condition.

Death of Player Characters

In this system, death is a genuine possibility—though it should not be a common one. Your characters may die, especially if they get into particularly dangerous combat or attempt something especially reckless time and again. That is okay!

Because of the episodic nature of your time travel adventures, if your character dies, you can (and should) build a new one! They may join the team immediately, or at the start of the next session. That is up to you and your GM.

If you as a player are particularly opposed to your character dying, then 1) don't get into especially dangerous combat or put yourself in particularly hazardous situations, and 2) talk to your GM ahead of time. Remember: in this system, death of your character does not mean you're out of the game. You can and should continue to play as a new character.

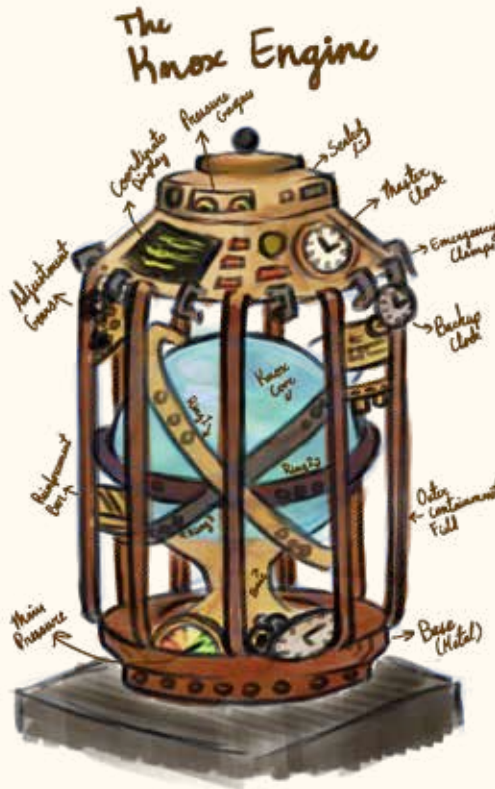
Time Travel Manual

What is Time?

Spacetime in *Rewind* is a roughly static four-dimensional continuum. It's usually visualized at LRU as a very long cylinder of coordinates at each infinitesimally small moment of Earth's history. In slightly simpler terms: time is (mostly) set in stone. Big events must happen as they originally did, or the fabric of time cannot sustain the change and creates a **paradox**—a hole/tear in time.

The Knox Engine

The Knox Engine is a relatively small core that is set into a larger people-carrying capsule. Its computer, in tandem with its time travelers, calculates coordinates for a temporal and spatial destination (four coordinates: three for position in space, and once for position in time). The capsules are of varying sizes and capabilities, but can't make more than a few jumps at a time before needing to recalibrate.



The Knox Engine keeps track of your original/starting coordinates, which is how you are able to return to the present. Should it decalibrate or otherwise destabilize, you may find yourself unable to return to the present, and will become stuck in time. That is incredibly dangerous, so LRU travelers are advised to return after every 2-3 jumps, or after every jump when nearing a paradox.

The Knox Engine *cannot* take you forward beyond its anchor in the present day, because we (and the engine) remain incapable of calculating coordinates in a forward temporal direction.

The Butterfly Effect

...Isn't a thing. Or *mostly* isn't a thing. That is, if you step on a butterfly whose wings flapping would've led to the extinction of the dinosaurs, that's okay. Another butterfly will take its place. Small changes to the timeline don't tend to affect the fabric of time; time is flexible to a point. Even affecting small things around a major event is fine, and will usually not have major impacts. But when you *do* affect a major event, or manipulate time such that it breaks, you get a **paradox**.



Paradoxes (Holes/Tears in Time)

Sometimes, time travelers have such an impact on the timeline that time cannot resolve itself. It could be because a major event doesn't happen as it should've, a minor event is messed up so badly it affects all of time itself, or something else goes catastrophically wrong. In an attempt to fix the problem, time will warp itself so badly that it rips open. This causes a **tear in time**, and the resulting void (which looks like a rapidly expanding fracture/crack in the very fabric of reality, beyond which is nothingness) is called a **hole in time**. The tear is the initial event, the hole is the resulting void.

If left unfixed, a hole in time will continue to expand throughout the location and time in which it began, and later forward and backward through time. Paradoxes are, as a result, incredibly dangerous and destructive. Nobody knows what happens when you touch one (or fall into one, or are consumed by one), except that you cease to exist. You just... disappear.

Resolving Paradoxes

Resolving paradoxes is a delicate thing, especially around a major temporal/historical event. In order to fix the paradox, you must stop, undo, or otherwise negate the event that caused it. In order for the paradox to resolve itself, events must return to very nearly how they originally occurred.

Time *wants* to fix itself. Paradoxes are an enormous problem for the stability of the timeline, so time will tend toward resolution (this is why the butterfly effect generally doesn't exist). When you, as time travelers, affect small things about the timeline in your efforts to prevent a paradox, that is okay. Time deals with it, because your prevention of the paradox fixes the largest issue.

But The Atoms...

Remember how you can change little things in order to fix a paradox? There is one exception to this: atoms displaced in time become unstable the longer they are removed from their original time. Multiple jumps back in time without returning to the original time makes this destabilization worse. This is why the Knox Engine has a tendency to destabilize and decalibrate when it jumps too many times before returning to its original time—and why it is dangerous for you, as time travelers, to go back too many times before returning to the present.

Normally, you'd have to spend hundreds of years back in time before your atoms would start to destabilize time. You could leave a pen behind in ancient Greece and, in almost every case, there would be no impact on time. Eventually, when destabilized enough, the pen would just disappear into the void. That is different around paradoxes.

Generally, the Knox Engine can only handle 1-2 jumps near a paradox before it begins to destabilize and decalibrate. And, more importantly, resolving a paradox requires ensuring that anything involved in the major event (or other paradoxical issue) is of the original time. For instance, say the Declaration of Independence was stolen right before its signing, and that caused a paradox. You couldn't just go back and replace the document with a counterfeit, because the atoms in it would destabilize exponentially faster around the paradox—and as a result, the paradox would never resolve itself. You'd have to go find the *original* Declaration of Independence or make a counterfeit entirely of materials from the right time period.

Regulations & Laws Surrounding Time Travel

Time travel only became possible nine years ago, and only became *really* doable by anyone but the absolute richest governments and corporations a few years ago. Generally, time is unregulated. Most countries have some form of anti-paradox law, but there is no license required to travel, and what you do when back in time is largely unpunishable. However, murder (see FAQ), stealing state secrets, and a few other present-day-connected crimes are occasionally prosecutable in the country in which they historically occurred, or in the country of origination (as designated by the Knox Engine's anchor point).

Frequently Asked Questions

What if I kill my parents?

First of all, don't. You're a trained time traveler at LRU, and you surely must understand the stupidity of killing your own parents.

That said, this is an easy one. Time wants to resolve itself, and the easiest way to do that is to keep your parents dead... and also you. There are no records of someone actually doing this, but if you did, you would just pop out of time altogether. Welcome to the void.

What if a little tiny thing does affect something major?

It would have to be a medium thing to do that. Generally, little things cannot make or break a major event. Medium things can, and that's why we have you all! Your job is to fix those medium (and larger) things.

I went back in time because there was a paradox. I solved it, so there was never a paradox. Isn't that a paradox in itself?

Look. We don't 100% know how time works. What we do know is that time tends toward resolution when possible. Paradoxes are really, really bad for the timestream. According to all existing research, when you travel back in time because of a paradox, and then prevent that paradox, nothing about your journey is erased. So the paradox is still resolved. Anything you picked up in the paradox timeline (or near the paradox) does disappear, though, so don't go looking for trinkets.

If my colleague dies while on a mission, can I go back and save them?

Pending department approval, you may be allowed to retrieve a colleague in the moments before their death. You will, however, need to show that the undoing of their death will not cause a paradox. If it is the case that their un-death will not significantly affect time, research shows it is a safe enough thing to do. But be careful about interacting with yourself and your colleagues when you do that—paradoxes can and have formed this way.

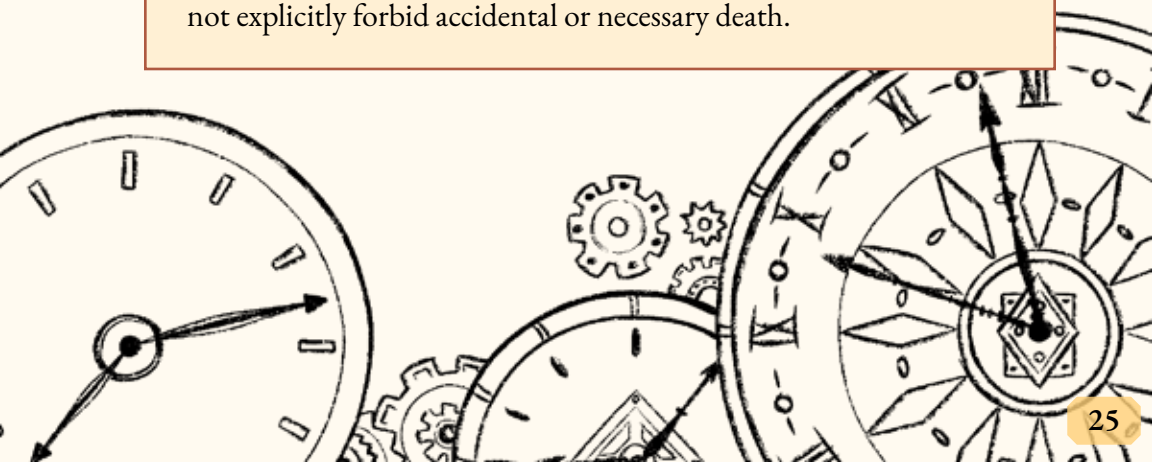
What happens if I injure or kill someone while on a mission?

Time-wise, as long as you've not injured or killed a major historical figure, that is fine.

University-wise, injuries are generally excusable. Death is... it depends. Did you kill a contemporary (someone from our present time)? That is a lot of paperwork, and occasionally a criminal trial. However, according to current legal precedent, you must be tried in the country where you committed the murder—unless they agree to move your trial to the country in which your Knox Engine existed before its time travel. The country in which the murder was committed will often decline to prosecute if the death directly enabled the resolution of a hole-in-time-causing paradox.

If you kill someone from the past whose death does not significantly affect the timeline, open a paradox, etc, that is generally excusable following a mountain of paperwork and a brief hearing at LRU to establish the facts and the necessity of the death.

Do not injure or kill without reason. If you have a significant reason, though, and at least one witness to back up said reason, LRU does not explicitly forbid accidental or necessary death.



Game Master's Guide

Welcome to the Game Master's Guide!

Here, you will find tools, tips, and tricks for being a Game Master (GM). Whether you're a seasoned GM just looking for *Rewind*-specific story and mechanics tips, or a first-time GM looking for guidance on how to lead a game, you've come to the right place. It is important to know that everything included in this guide is a suggestion. At the end of the day, what matters most is that you and your players have fun!

Running Your First Adventure

The Day the Emperor Died is a great first adventure to run for your players. Everything you need is available in book form and on the website. A few resources (like a map, for instance) that your players might need are also available on the website, locked until you give your players the password (see the physical or digital copy of the first adventure for passwords).

Before you run the adventure, read through the entire module and take a look at the resources. These will include character sheets, any relevant visuals, and a few sections that explain how particular characters think & how you might roleplay them. If you're a first-time GM, read through this guide as well! You may find it helpful to read this first, and then turn your attention to the adventure itself.

Throughout the first adventure, there are numerous points of flexibility. You might skip over some scenes or pieces of scenes if your players are moving particularly slowly, or you might add in and adjust things as needed to fit your group. All of this is okay and encouraged! You, as the GM, should feel free to tailor this adventure to work with your own GMing style and the play style of your group.

Preparing Your Players

In order to run an adventure, you'll need to have at least one player. You can play the first adventure (and any story you design in this system) with any number of players, though it tends to work best with 2-6 players. Stories you

design in this system can be run for any number of players, and because of the episodic nature of the system, the same players/characters do not have to show up for each session (more on this later).

To prepare your players for their first mission back in time, have them read through the Rules Compendium (this thing you're reading right now). Players only need to be familiar with the introduction, character creation, and combat & wounds sections. Alternatively, you (the GM) can explain the rules to your players when they arrive for their first session. Either works!

Then, have your players create their characters. You can either do this physically, by printing out copies of the character sheet and having your players write everything down, or digitally, by directing your players to the digital character sheet. There, they can follow a tutorial on how to create a character from scratch. Or, if they are feeling particularly spontaneous, they can generate a completely random character.

Encourage your players to think of their characters as imperfect, perhaps unusual people. They don't all have to be expert time travelers or tenured professors—they can, and should, think outside the box.

Historical Player Characters

It is up to you whether or not you wish to allow historical player characters—that is, characters who come from the past and have somehow wound up at LRU working for the Department of Temporal Research. You may choose to allow historical characters but not *named* historical figures, you may allow both, or you may not allow historical characters at all. This is **100% a GM decision**. It is up to you! Though the system was originally built with contemporary characters in mind, you can (and should) opt for the most interesting thing. Want to run a game where everyone plays historic US Presidents suddenly working for LRU? Go right ahead!

As with almost everything in this system, your choice about whether or not to allow historical characters, how many of them to allow, etc. should depend on what is a) most interesting and b) most comedic. Don't be afraid to bend the rules a little bit if it's funny.

Other Player Character Creation Notes

Your players, especially if they are new, may need a little extra guidance on making their characters. In the appendix there are a few optional rolling tables for occupation, background, etc. which you can direct your players to if they want to create a random character (or draw a little inspiration from the options).

You can also encourage people to try out a character for a one-shot, and if they don't like that character, make a new one! The episodic nature of this system means that they aren't stuck with the character they make first (see later discussion on episodic structure and flexibility).



Storytelling & Role-playing

If you're a new GM, storytelling and role-playing can feel daunting. Don't worry! You've got this. Below are a few tips and tricks for running the adventures, whether pre-written or created by you. The most important thing to remember is: you don't need to (and shouldn't) be perfect, nor must you stick to the script exactly. Aim to create a fun experience for you and your players above all else.

When it comes to role-playing, it's up to you whether you do voices, whether you speak as non-player characters (NPCs) at all, or whether you stick to narration alone. What you prefer will shift over time—many GMs (and players) start out uncomfortable with role-play, and learn to love it over time. Whether you come into GMing as a master voice actor or you've never acted/improvised in your life, you can succeed and have fun! The first adventure contains short guides for roleplaying the major characters, which give you information about their appearance, personality, and what they might say/do in response to the players. Make sure you've read these before running the adventure, and don't be afraid to try out speaking as each character beforehand (if you decide to use direct dialogue to tell parts of the story).

As you move past the first adventure and create your own characters, you might find it helpful to write down a few notes about their personality and behaviors, which will help you transition to role-playing as NPCs that you've created.

Storytelling can also feel tricky. What pieces of the story can you skip? What is essential? What if players are taking too long, or moving too quickly?

What if the players just keep missing something you need them to know? A lot of this can be solved by improvising, but if you're new to GMing, that may not feel natural. That is okay!

The first adventure contains particular pieces of information and story beats that are flexible/skippable depending on your players—but don't be afraid to play around with other beats of the story and change details as you like.

Once again, when it comes to role-playing, storytelling, and everything else GM-related, your number one goal is for you and your players to have fun—everything else is flexible.



Running Combat

When your players encounter combat, first ask them to roll **initiative** (discussed in the “Combat & Wounds” section of this book). You'll also need to roll initiative for any non-player characters (NPCs) who are involved in the combat. Note down everyone's scores, including the NPCs, from highest to lowest. **The highest score goes first** (takes a turn), and so on down the list. When you get to the bottom, repeat!

When running combat in *Rewind*, the “rule of cool” applies. That means if your players have a crazy idea, perhaps related to an eccentricity of theirs or otherwise wild, it is good to encourage that! Let them roll for whatever wild action they're doing—just make sure it doesn't exceed what they could reasonably do on a turn (for instance, crossing a large room, stealing a key out of a safe and unlocking a door would be far more than one turn of action).

When it's time for your NPCs to take turns, don't focus on killing the player characters (PCs). Instead, think about what that particular NPC might do. Are they a guard, and intent on arresting someone or protecting someone else? Are they likely to flee from combat, or face it head on? Your goal is not to go as hard as possible on your players, but rather to further the narrative and push players toward their end goal.

And on that note, combat generally shouldn't last for very long. Eventually, someone will likely flee, or get grievously injured, or achieve what they were trying to do. Don't be afraid of a short combat.

In *Rewind*, the best combat is a goal-oriented combat, in which the players have some goal other than “kill all the bad guys.” That makes for a more interesting and fun experience, and works better with the combat & wound mechanics of *Rewind*. When designing your own combats/encounters, keep this in mind! It is okay (good, even) for combat to end because the enemy is restrained, or got away, was talked down, or is otherwise no longer able or willing to fight.



Handling Player Character Death

Every now and then, a PC might die. That is part of the system, but how okay you as a GM are with death will vary based on your own style and the preferences of your players. Encourage that player to quickly roll up a new character who can show up, if it's a longer adventure—or you can even hand them an NPC to play, if you want! Alternatively, they can make a new character before the next adventure. Death means that particular character can't show up anymore, but it doesn't mean the player is out of the group. Make sure your players understand that 1) death is possible and 2) death is okay. These characters are, largely, normal-ish people; they're not meant to be indestructible.

If you *really* don't want to kill any player characters, you can fudge time. See the *Time Travel Manual's* FAQ for one option (going back to save that character in the moments before they die). You may scale back combat if it's proving too difficult, or introduce something that gives the players an advantage, or even send some emergency medics from LRU to the scene to save them. While death is part of *Rewind*, it's okay if you and your party want to circumvent it at times. That is up to you, the GM.

An Episodic System

Rewind, unlike many popular TTRPG systems, is not meant to be a campaign-focused system. That is, you don't need the same players with the same characters to show up every week, and you don't even need the same GM across every adventure. This is meant to help new players get into the system easier (without the commitment of many months or years of playing) and to help you, the GM, run your adventures without endless scheduling hurdles.

Each adventure, or mission, is meant to last one session of 1-4 hours. The starter adventure, for instance, is generally a 2-3 hour adventure (depending on the number of players and what they choose to do). At the end of most sessions/missions, your PCs will return to LRU to report on the results of their mission and rest up for the next one. This means that players (and characters) can shift between missions. In-universe, LRU puts various different people on different missions—so the players/characters who aren't present for a session simply aren't assigned to that mission. The intention here is to be flexible, and to allow you to run many adventures with varying groups of people over time.

For instance, you might run the first adventure with a group of four people. Two of those people can't make it to the next session, but one other person wants to join. That is absolutely okay! Those two missing players' characters just weren't assigned to the next adventure, but the new player's character was.

Or, say one of your players wants to try out a new character. Encourage them to! Players can have a rotating cast of 2-3 (or more) characters they play depending on the mission. GMs could even change between missions—you might have a few who all want to write and run adventures, and those GMs can rotate who GMs and who plays.

All of this is meant to make *Rewind* a flexible, episodic system in which players and characters can shift between adventures. That said, if you want to write an adventure that takes 2-3 sessions to run, or want to weave a longer story into episodic missions, that can also be fun and engaging. You might add in small pieces of story in each mission that point to one big bad guy (or organization, etc) over time, or do something else to build a long-term story, and that can be an excellent way to create a thread of continuity between each adventure.

Writing Your Own Adventures

So: you've played the first adventure, your players had fun and want to keep playing, and now you've got to come up with your own stories. How do you do that?

Start by picking out a setting and an objective for your players to complete. Think about what places/times in history might be fun for a one-shot. Are your players going to solve a historical mystery? Fix a paradox? Save a colleague who is trapped somewhere in the past? Or something completely different? It is entirely up to you. If you're stuck for ideas, try randomly picking a place and time period, and see what you can come up with.

For adventures/missions that take 2-3 hours, you will often want:

- No more than two jumps back in time (usually one, but as the first adventure shows, a short additional jump can work well)
- One major puzzle-like piece of the story (whether that's sneaking in somewhere, solving a mystery, figuring out what happened, etc)
- A few interesting NPCs for players to talk to/interact with
- One combat or other physical encounter that gives your more physically-oriented characters a chance to shine (but, perhaps, can also be solved with some ingenious non-physical solution)

And a clear objective for your players to accomplish! That doesn't always have to be revealed right away. For instance, your players might go back in time intending to solve a historical mystery, but realize that there is another time traveler causing trouble, and their *true* objective might become "stop the trouble-causing time traveler."

You can, of course, include more than one puzzle-like story piece and/or more than one combat. Just make sure to balance your story. The starter adventure, for example, has multiple possible encounters that can lead to combat, but only one combat that is likely to happen. There are a few different puzzle-like sections—players have to identify the paradox's source, figure out how to get into the house, and figure out how to fix the paradox—but they are all interconnected, and can all be approached a few different ways.

Think about what story beats and encounters might be fun for your players (and you). What might be a satisfying ending? How can you plan for things going wrong? Will your players be able to fail this mission, or will you guide them toward success? All of this is up to you, and will depend on your style and your group's preferences.

How to Make an NPC

To make an NPC (non-player character), follow the standard character creation steps to start. Then, modify your NPC to fit your story. Do they have an expertise or not? Are their talents specific to a backstory you've made for them, or should they be random? Pick out a name (or randomly generate one), put together a short backstory, and you're ready to go!

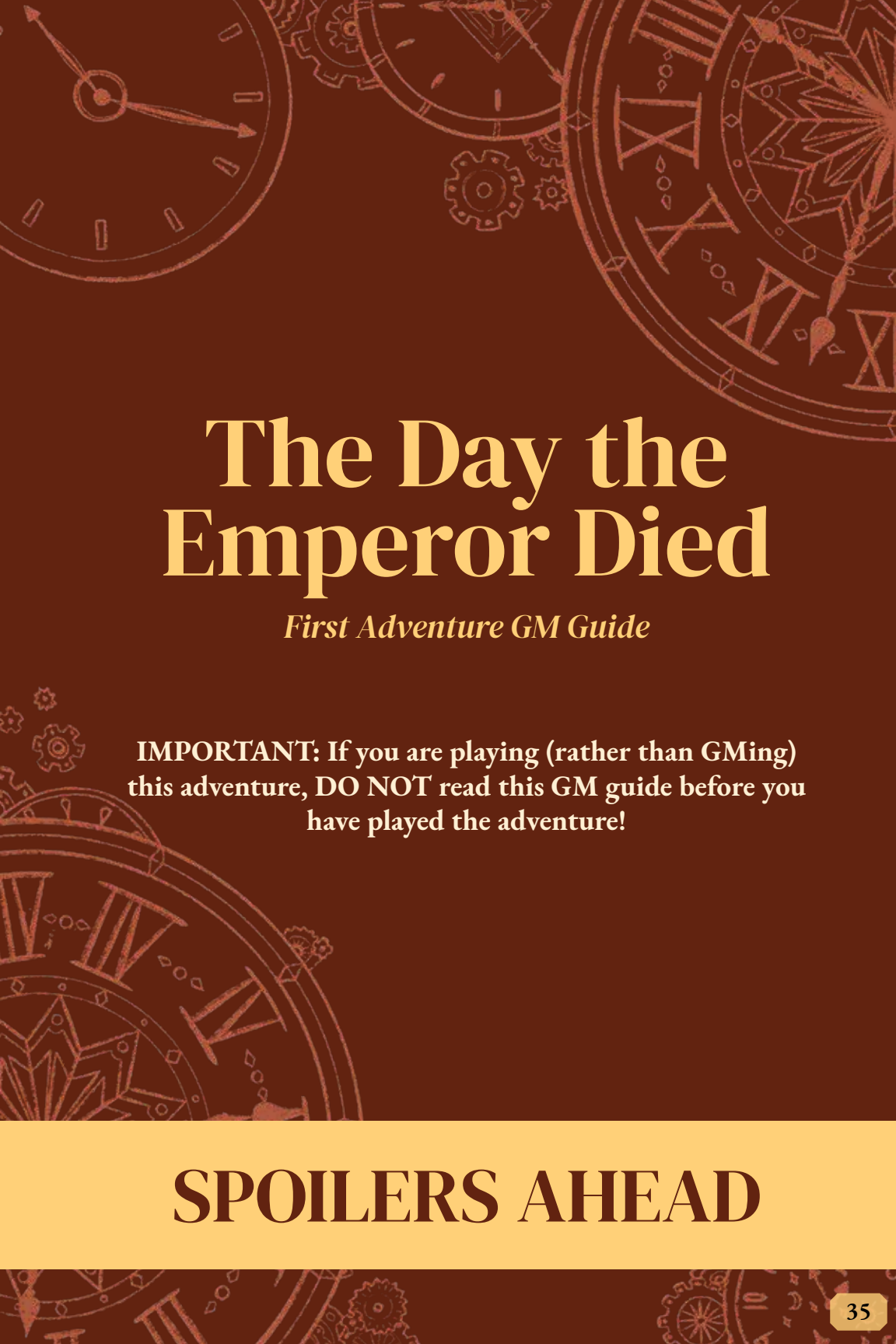
Of course, if your NPC is critical to the adventure or you're planning to have them appear over multiple sessions as a recurring character, you'll want to flesh them out a little more. Think about their core motivations and quirks. What do they want most? How far are they willing to go to get it? What about them is usual, and what about them is unusual? What state of mind are they usually in? How do they feel about the PCs? All of these (and more!) are questions you can ask to help you build and play a fleshed out character.

Final Notes and Guidance

If you're a new GM, remember above all else: have fun! Your goal, as stated many times in this GM guide, is to create a fun, engaging experience for yourself and your players. Whether you're running the starter adventure or writing and running your own story, remember that you don't have to be perfect. *Rewind* is a system about comedy, fun, and interest. So don't take yourself too seriously, and don't put too much pressure on yourself to be magnificent the first time around.

You will GM many times before it feels comfortable and easy. Maybe it never quite will, and that is okay! You will adapt your style, experiment, and become better every time you GM. So get out there, find some players, and get started!





The Day the Emperor Died

First Adventure GM Guide

IMPORTANT: If you are playing (rather than GMing) this adventure, **DO NOT** read this GM guide before you have played the adventure!

SPOILERS AHEAD



The Day The Emperor Died

How to Run This Adventure

This adventure contains material for a 2-3 hour session in which players will complete a time travel mission back into Ancient Rome and prevent a paradox caused by Caesar not being assassinated. Included is the main storyline and guidance to keep your players on track, critical plot points, modules for combat and other possible encounters, pieces of narration for important beats of the story, guidance for playing the important non-player characters (NPCs), and every character sheet and stat block you will need.

You should read through this adventure at least once before running it and make sure you are familiar with the main modules and encounters before you begin your session. Practice the most important bits of narration and make sure you know what to do when your players (inevitably) make a crazy decision and try something unusual. That is good! This adventure is meant to encourage problem-solving and ingenious thinking on the part of the players.

Starting the Adventure

It is just past two on a Tuesday morning in early spring when the players each get an emergency call from Dr. Naomi Eaton, Assistant Director of the Department of Temporal Research at LRU. Start the adventure as the players arrive at LRU in the capsule bay, a warehouse-like building partially underneath the campus.

The time capsule bay is modern, but is built in the basement of a much older building that still has columns and an engraved motto on the outside. The bay itself has a grey concrete floor and matching grey concrete walls, and in the center of the enormous room sit three capsules, each some 12-14 feet tall,

in shades of silver and gold metal, with blue light spilling out from inside. Large lamps attached to the ceiling of the bay light up automatically as the players enter.

As the players arrive at the bay, it is a good time to ask each of them to introduce and describe their characters. As part of their introduction, ask them to describe what their character was doing just before they got the call and headed to LRU/the capsule bay.

At one door, a security guard is nodding off, a book of sudoku puzzles in hand. Dr. Eaton is already in the analytics booth above the main bay, a smaller room accessed by a small metal staircase on the far side of the capsule bay. She explains that she wasn't the one who was on duty, the security guard was. The large flashing red light above the analytics booth and the siren woke him up, and he called her immediately. She tells the players they've got to come take a look at the problem.

Note: You may choose to describe what Dr. Eaton tells the players, or play her yourself and do this intro piece as dialogue. Most likely, you will want to use a combination of the two. It is completely up to you and your players how much banter & dialogue happens in this section! If your players want to banter with Dr. Eaton, encourage that! It can set a fun and collaborative tone for the adventure.

Large glass windows on one side of the analytics booth look out over the bay, and the rest of the room is covered in computers and monitors. Dr. Eaton shows the players a diagram projected onto one wall of the timestream. A black dot has appeared in the year 44 BCE in Ancient Rome. She shows the players a zoomed-in view, and they can see that a tear in time is forming on March 15th, 44 BCE. Dr. Eaton mentions that this is the date of Julius Caesar's assassination, and the location of the tear looks like it could be related.

Dr. Eaton hands the players a device called a Paradox Sensor, which is a mechanical Geiger-counter-esque device that ticks faster as it nears a tear in time. This, Dr. Eaton explains, will help the players locate exactly where the

source of the problem is. Their first job is to identify the issue. Their second is to solve it. Dr. Eaton warns them that this may involve multiple trips, which are more likely to de-calibrate the Knox Engine when they're close to a paradox. After they've figured out what caused the problem, they should head straight back to LRU to figure out what to do. Dr. Eaton tells them that if they need other resources or information at that time, she'll do some digging to prepare.

Gearing Up

Dr. Eaton heads back down to the capsule bay, where she throws open the cabinets of gear and clothing. At this point, you can slyly let players know that if they want particular weaponry, protection, costumes, or any other gear, they can ask Dr. Eaton. She will approve some weaponry (including 1-2 firearms among the party), but very little ammunition. It is up to you what else she approves—generally, though, the “rule of cool” applies. Think it could be interesting or funny? Dr. Eaton can approve it, then! Try to keep it to period-accurate gear, though, unless you're intentionally aiming for an anachronistic adventure.

The players gather anything they may need for a trip back in time, don costumes appropriate for Ancient Rome, and get into their capsule. The players travel back to Rome on the day where the tear has appeared.

Role-playing Dr. Naomi Eaton

Dr. Naomi Eaton is the players' first introduction to the world of LRU. She is in her 50s, and her black hair dotted with grey is pulled tight into a bun. She has glasses that sit at the edge of her nose, wears a long grey coat over a button up and suit pants, and carries her computer with her in one hand at all times. She floats back and forth between being a distracted academic and a detailed manager. On this particular day, she's frazzled. Like everyone else, she's been woken up in the middle of the night and is suddenly trying to prevent the space-time continuum from ripping itself apart.

Role-playing Dr. Naomi Eaton (Cont'd)

She will raise her eyebrow at whatever schemes the players are planning, but she trusts them to fix the problem. And, when they return from their first trip, she will ask them questions that lead them toward what's gone wrong (if they're still struggling to figure out what happened). She's observant, and thinking ahead—so when she sees the post asking for Brutus's dagger on a collector's forum, she starts to put the pieces together.



The First Trip Back to Rome

The players arrive in Ancient Rome and step out of their pod into a small plaza, or forum. Immediately, it is clear that something has gone wrong. There is chaos; Roman denizens run through the plaza shouting and waving their hands. From doorways of shops and homes, nervous and scared faces peek out, unwilling to venture into the chaos.

Even from here, the players' Paradox Sensor is already ticking. Remind them that their in-ear comms will translate any language spoken (if nearby/in ear-shot). If they choose to investigate before following the sensor's ticking, they will hear snippets of conversation that point to a great tragedy having unfolded, though they can't catch exactly what happened.

When the players follow the sensor's ticking, it leads them to a large house. This is not the time for particularly crazy antics, but players may investigate as they like in the following scene and during pauses in the narration. Discoverable clues and useful witnesses are described throughout the following section.

Narration (once the players arrive at the grand residence that their Paradox Sensor points them toward):

In front of you is a palatial home. Marble frescos decorate the entrance. Your sensors click faster the closer you get. Whatever happened to cause a tear in time happened here.

Narration (Cont'd)

But it doesn't take a sensor to know something is wrong. People sit on the steps of the building, weeping. The door is cracked open and unguarded.

You walk into a grand courtyard. It's crowded with people, panicking, wailing. You push through the crowd, and as you do, you see the problem. In the center of the room lie two well-dressed men, both stabbed through the heart, blood pooling around them. A single dagger lies between them.

You hear names amongst the panic of the crowd. Marcus Junius Brutus. Gaius Cassius Longinus. Brutus and Cassius, Caesar's would-be assassins, dead on the floor, on the morning of the Ides of March.

You may choose to have players roll perception checks to notice particular pieces of potential evidence/witnesses, or you may choose to narrate them regardless. At the edge of the crowd, clutching Cassius's hand, is a woman in elegant clothing with a circlet on her head. She looks distressed and panicked. This appears to be a relation of Cassius's—his wife. If the players speak to her, she explains reluctantly that her husband had been distracted with some large plan, and laid his dagger out the night before. He was supposed to go to the Senate this morning.

Around the edges of the room stand servants and guards who appear to be standing watch. They also look distressed, but have not joined the chaotic crowd around the bodies. The servants and guards will report that early this morning, Brutus arrived looking frantic. Shortly after, they were sent out to carry messages to other Senators with the words "we are discovered." They don't know what happened afterward, but when they returned, Cassius and Brutus were already dead.

If players inspect Cassius and Brutus, they notice that Brutus is still in a cloak, as though he was traveling through the city and arrived shortly before his death. Both senators are dressed well, like they were going somewhere important (to the senate). Both have wounds through their hearts, and a bloody dagger lies between them with Cassius's initials on it (you may wish to make the player investigating roll for Aware to notice that it is Cassius's dagger/initials). It appears that both men were stabbed with the same dagger.

Note: though you shouldn't volunteer this information to players (or highlight it) just yet, if players ask, Brutus's dagger is nowhere to be found.

The Tear Opens

As players are investigating, pick a moment to have them all roll for Aware. Read the following (or your adaptation of it) aloud, with the idea that everyone who succeeded sees this immediately. Make sure that the players have sufficient evidence to return to LRU before you narrate the tear in time, so that if they choose to flee immediately, they still leave with enough.

Narration:

And then, above the bodies, you see it. At first it's just a ripple in the air, but then it splinters open. A crack, a void just a few feet above the bodies. Your sensors go wild. You all stumble backwards as the tear in time expands through the air and the crowd rushes, afraid, toward the doors.

Ask your players what they are all doing in this moment. Are they going to run with the crowd? Stay to investigate just a little more? Pursue some other course of action? Follow your players in what they choose to do, and have the hole in time expand as slowly or as quickly as you need it to for the sake of the plot. Narrate its expansion, which becomes increasingly dangerous for the players to be around.

If the players attempt to go to the senate, to Julius Caesar's house, or anywhere else, you may a) choose to allow it, and improvise that scene, or b) remind them that the hole in time is destabilizing time itself around them, and they need to return to LRU soon lest their Knox Engine destabilize.

Narration (as the players return to their capsule; this is optional):

As you fly back through the alleys toward your capsule, you catch words from the citizens of Rome, just close enough for your in-ear comms to translate. More than 60 senators, found dead in their homes, stabbed by their own daggers.

If the players have any last-minute things they want to do, let them. Then, they shut their capsule and tell it to head for home.



Return to LRU

The crew returns to LRU having discovered the source of the paradox, and likely with theories about what happened. Dr. Eaton helps them out of the capsule and asks them what they found. If they mention the dagger, Dr. Eaton first confirms: “Wait. There was only one dagger?”

Plutarch’s History

Dr. Eaton pulls up Plutarch’s History and explains a few things to the players (you may omit anything that your players evidently already know):

- Cassius, Brutus, and more than 60 other senators planned to assassinate Caesar to prevent his rise as an emperor.
- They intended to do so each with their own dagger, on March 15th, 44 BCE, when Caesar arrived at the Senate—which was, at the time, held at the Theater of Pompey, as the usual venue had burned down.
- Caesar arrived late, and almost didn’t show, but when he did arrive, the 60+ senators carried out their assassination as planned.
- **However:** Cassius had a contingency plan. If their plot was discovered, the senators were to turn their daggers on themselves.

Then, as players discuss (give this a moment, your players will likely want to think this through out loud and/or in-character), Dr. Eaton says she's been scouring the internet for information on the assassination and saw a post in one common artifact hunter forum where someone requested Brutus's dagger as a collector's item. It looks like someone may have stolen the dagger, and that led to his belief that he had been discovered (let your players come to this realization on their own, if possible). Only one person left a comment on the post: someone named MacMillan. If your players try to investigate his identity, it is up to you whether or not this can succeed. If you'd like, you can provide more information about him—but be wary of improvising too much information here, lest your players try to travel within the present to stop him from ever going back in time at all.

Note: If at all possible, the players should make the final connections to realize that Brutus's dagger was stolen, and as a result he thought he'd been found out (and went to Cassius, and then they stabbed themselves). But Dr. Eaton is there to scaffold the players' discovery, and can give them suggestions/support if they are stuck.

At this point, the players should be able to piece together that Brutus believed he had been discovered, told Cassius, and they killed themselves. And, with the prompting of Dr. Eaton, if needed, players should reach the conclusion that Brutus's panic had something to do with his dagger, which seems to have potentially been stolen for a present-day collector.

The Replica Dagger

After the players realize what caused the paradox, Dr. Eaton tells them to wait a moment. A few minutes later, she comes back and shows them a replica dagger she requisitioned (read: purloined, assuming she would have been granted permission if she had the time to ask) from the LRU Museum of History. The dagger, a copy of Brutus's, was commissioned based on data from a previous mission back in time to after the assassination. It is made from similar materials, but is not the original dagger. Dr. Eaton hands this over to the

players along with their real mission: travel back to the night before Caesar's assassination and prevent Brutus's real dagger from being stolen by whatever artifact hunter intended to sell it to a collector.

How they do this is completely up to them, but Dr. Eaton makes it very clear that they must make sure Brutus wakes the next morning and takes the real dagger. There is a clear and present danger in leaving a modern replica somewhere in ancient history, because its modernity could upset time and cause another, smaller, compounding paradox (look at the Time Travel Manual in the Rules Compendium for more information on the temporal mechanics going on here). Dr. Eaton mentions, though, that if the replica dagger is lost in their adventures, as long as Brutus ends up with the real dagger (not the replica), that is okay. She says the university museum will probably forgive her little indiscretion if the players prevent time from being ripped apart.

Ask the players if they are making any preparations or planning anything. If they require extra weaponry, tools, etc, Dr. Eaton allows them to take what they need—though she still doesn't allow them to take too much ammunition for any weapon. This is to encourage players to eventually trap MacMillan through more ingenious methods than just... shooting him. Although that is a valid way of doing things. It's also to build Dr. Eaton's character as someone in charge of the department who can't/won't freely approve all weapons/ammunition.

Then, have the players describe when and where they are headed in time. They are free to look at a map of Rome in 44 BCE (this resource does not actually exist, but you can narrate that they have access to it) to land in an ideal location. The time of day is important to inquire about, since it will affect their interaction with MacMillan's original heist timeline.

The Night of March 14th, 44 BCE

The players arrive in their capsule near Brutus's house. From here, it is up to the players what they will do. They know there is a time traveler who will show up some time after Brutus has gone to bed to steal the dagger, and they have the replica dagger (or should have it, unless they refused it).

Layout of Brutus's House

There are two guards outside the main entrance to Brutus's house. The back entrance has only one guard. Two other guards circle the building together—it takes about five to seven minutes for them to make a complete round. All the guards are armed with spears and swords. Both doors are strong, wooden and reinforced with iron. The main door leads to an atrium (open-air courtyard). There are windows around the house, on both the first and second floors, but they are covered by ornamental iron grilles that cannot be opened on the first floor, and by wooden lattice shutters on the second. The walls on the side of the house are plastered over and decorated, which makes them not-that-climable. Inside, rooms surround the main courtyard. To the left is the study, where (unbeknownst to the players) Brutus has laid his dagger. To the right is a large dining room. The back holds chairs in an outdoor lounge, and an entrance to the open-air garden. The kitchen is adjacent to the garden in the back right.

The players will not know the layout of the house initially. They'll only know where the entrances are (by circling the building and staking it out). Once they are inside, they will be able to explore the various rooms and get a feeling for the layout—if they sneak throughout the house successfully, give them the **house map**. You can find the map on the adjacent page, or on the website (under the GM's first adventure guide, also accessible from the Player Resources page).

Getting Into Brutus's House

There are a number of ways to do this. The players can distract guards at one of the entrances, convince the guards to let them in, get into a fight and incapacitate the guards, or try something completely different. Roll with your players here—the guards at the entrances will be somewhat distractable, but the guards rounding the house may see the players if they're not careful. They will be harder to convince than to distract, and fighting (if loud) will draw the attention of the circling guards. Use the guards' character sheet (same for all five guards) and roll to see if they notice, should players try a sneakier method.

Map of Brutus's House



Note: The guard at the back of the house will lock the back entrance and join the two circling guards around the time that MacMillan starts to sneak into the study (~12:30). This is so players can pick/break the lock and get into the house in time for a potential confrontation with MacMillan; no player should be absolutely and permanently stuck outside the house once MacMillan shows up. You may modify this timeline to suit the needs of your group—though getting into the house is intended to be a puzzle, if your players are particularly frustrated, you may give them a nice opportunity to sneak in when a guard shift changes, or when a guard goes to use the bathroom, etc. **Make sure all players have the opportunity to get inside the house before confronting MacMillan.** Some players may intentionally stay outside, and that is okay, but encourage everyone to get into the house eventually.

Running into MacMillan

The players will not know this, but MacMillan is already in the house. He snuck in an hour or so before Brutus went to bed, and has been hiding in the house since. It is up to you, the Game Master, as to where exactly in the house he has been hiding. He's disguised as a servant. That means that the players, try as they might, cannot prevent MacMillan from ever getting in. By the time they show up, he's already lying in wait.

The players don't know exactly when MacMillan will "arrive" (show up in the study, since he's already in the house). Leave this up to chance and the players' strategy.

If the players aim to arrive *after* MacMillan, they can do so easily by waiting until they see movement in the study. Waiting for someone to sneak in through the entrances won't work, though, so if the players try that, hours will pass and they may start to wonder. At that point, MacMillan might sneak out and the players will have to follow him.

If they want to arrive before him, they'll need to stake out the house and sneak in. No matter what time they do this, ensure that they eventually run into MacMillan. If they arrive before he does, he shows up while they are in the study. If they arrive after (or while he is leaving), they cross paths unexpectedly. You may need to bend the rules (or fudge MacMillan's timeline) in

order to get the players to encounter him. That is okay! The most important thing is that at some point MacMillan and the players will run into each other.

“What Ifs” and Important Points

What follows is a list of plot pieces and events that you may run into while running the second half of this adventure, when the players return to Rome to reverse heist the dagger back to its place. This includes a complete timeline of MacMillan’s heist, combat tips and tricks, etc.

Roleplaying the Guards

The guards are uptight and well-trained, suspicious of everyone but not particularly smart. All of them will be hesitant to believe the players (if players attempt to lie), but can be convinced if the players succeed on their rolls. If they can tell the players are trying to sneak in, they will respond with minimal force. See **Combat with the Guards**.

Roleplaying MacMillan

MacMillan is a slimy artifact hunter who makes his living by disrupting history without any regard for historical integrity. He hasn’t thought far enough ahead to realize that there will be a huge tear in time tomorrow; he is solely focused on taking the dagger and getting paid. He dislikes LRU because they’re too controlling, and dislikes every historical and governmental institution for the same reason. He’s in it for himself. He’s tricky, though, and cunning—or he wouldn’t have made it this far in his profession. He’s not going to be easily persuaded, and he’s going to try to weasel his way out of any confrontation. He does not want to kill the players unless there is no alternative—but he does carry a pistol and a knife in case he needs them (see MacMillan’s character sheet).

Combat with the Guards

The guards are determined to keep Brutus and family safe. If the players appear to be a danger or are caught trying to break in, the guards will fight them. Initially, the guards will only threaten the players and tell them to leave. Should they keep trying, the guards will draw weapons. Eventually, if the players make a move, are aggressive, or refuse to leave, the guards will draw blood. See the guards' character sheet.

- If this battle is too loud (have players roll for stealth) or lasts more than three rounds, the guards call for backup.
- It will take their backup one round to arrive. At that point, the two circling guards will show up and join the fight.
- The guards' objective is initially to incapacitate and tie up the players. If the fight lasts long enough for backup to arrive, their objective shifts: they now want to kill the players, who they see as fierce enemies.

Combat with MacMillan

Players may encounter MacMillan in a variety of locations, at a variety of points in the heist. Most likely, they will either: enter the study while MacMillan is already there, MacMillan will enter while they are there, or the players and MacMillan will have a confrontation on the street after MacMillan has already taken the dagger. If one of the players enters the library after Brutus has gone to bed, MacMillan is hiding there and will immediately pull his gun and threaten the character who has run into him. In all cases, refer to **MacMillan's character sheet for stats**.

- MacMillan is getting paid for fetching the real dagger, so that is his singular goal. Whatever he has to do to get the dagger and flee, he will. He is not, however, likely to spot the difference between the fake dagger and the real one.

Combat with MacMillan (Cont'd)

- MacMillan will threaten the players with a gun, which is in his gear, but he's unlikely to shoot at any of them unless he is severely wounded. If he enters an Adrenaline turn, he does as much damage as he can to whoever wounded him severely.
- The players should be able to take down MacMillan without too much trouble, but they'll have to be inventive. He wants to escape, not stay and fight, so they'll need to stop him.
- The guards are part of this combat. Roll for their initiative (they all act on the same turn). Each turn, roll for the guards to notice the commotion in the house. If they succeed, they begin moving into the house and towards the study as fast as they can.



MacMillan's Heist Timeline (before player intervention)

Note: you may change any of this, whether it is in the moment or beforehand. This heist timeline is a guide, but not a strict ruleset on how to run the adventure. Like the rest of this adventure, and the system itself, comedy and interest should come before adherence to specific rules.

Around midnight, Brutus goes to bed. Unbeknownst to anyone in the house, MacMillan has already snuck in. He's hiding out in the garden, library, or elsewhere (wherever is convenient and/or funny), waiting for the house to quiet down before he tries to steal.

At around 12:30 or so (you can move this to any time after Brutus goes to bed), he is convinced that the house has settled down, so he sneaks into the study. There, he takes the dagger from its ceremonial perch where Brutus laid it out and shoves it in his satchel.

He returns to the courtyard, where he waits for the two circling guards to go around the front of the building. Then, because he is dressed like a servant, he bribes the guard at the back, claims he's going out for a drink, and sneaks out the back entrance. His capsule is parked a few blocks away, so he goes around front and heads into the night.

After the Heist

Having succeeded in stopping MacMillan, the players return to their capsule (they may be taking MacMillan, living or dead, with them) and head back to LRU. There, Dr. Eaton greets them and shows them that the timeline is no longer in danger. They've done it!

If any of the players took Cassius's dagger from the first trip back to Rome, narrate that they check their pocket (or wherever they put it), but the dagger is gone. Vanished into thin air, because the paradox never existed, so they never picked up the dagger. Time resolves this by disappearing the dagger, because the paradox's resolution re-stabilizes time.

If the players did anything particularly paperwork-causing, like killing MacMillan or similar antics, Dr. Eaton asks them what happened. She acts exasperated, but a little amused. If the players kill MacMillan, she mentions that she's got a lot of paperwork to fill out, but she doubts Italy will care to prosecute, since the players fixed a paradox that would've changed history forever and torn time apart completely.

What if my players fail?

If you're wondering about this, good for you for thinking ahead! Because this is a first mission, you don't want your players to fail. Ideally, this module is written such that with the help of you, the GM, the players will succeed and return home triumphant.

If your players completely mess things up, improvise a little! Give them a second chance, or even another trip back in time to fix the bits they messed up terribly. But in pursuit of player success, don't be afraid to change some of the module up to make things easier, harder, or just *different*. And if you need to improvise to help your players out of a tough spot, that is okay.



Appendix A: Glossary of Terms

Generic Tabletop Role-playing Terms

TTRPG: Tabletop role-playing game (this game!).

GM: The Game Master; the person running the game.

PC: Player character, a character that a player at the table/in the game plays and controls.

NPC: Non-player character, a character that the GM plays and controls.

1d20: One twenty-sided die. This applies to all #d# structured terms (1d100 is one hundred-sided die, 5d6 is five six-sided dice, etc).

Session: When everyone gets together to play a TTRPG. Notoriously difficult to schedule, but not in *Rewind*!

Rewind Game/Mechanical Terms

Advantage: Rolling with two dice and (in *Rewind*) taking the lower of the two.

Disadvantage: Rolling with two dice and (in *Rewind*) taking the higher of the two.

Abilities: Core traits of a character that determine how good/bad they are at particular things.

Sturdy: A special ability only used in combat to withstand getting hit.

Eccentricities: Odd little talents and interests that a character has picked up along the way.

Expertise: A character's field of study, or the area of history (or other disciplines) that they know the most about.

Wounds: Measurements of damage a character has sustained, whether in combat or out of combat.

Gear: The tools and items a character carries with them on their missions. Can change by mission.

Mission: An adventure (often one session long) that the players embark on, usually assigned by LRU.

Adventure: The same thing as a mission. Used interchangeably.

Rewind & LRU Lore Terms

LRU: Large Research University (yes, that really is its name); the university that your characters work for.

Department of Temporal Research: The time-travel-researching department at LRU that your characters work for.

Knox Engine: The machine that makes time travel possible, invented nine years ago by Letitia Knox.

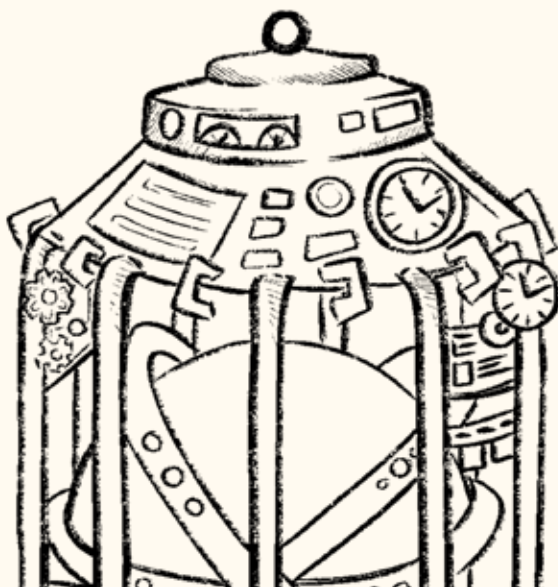
Time Capsule: A cylindrical-ish pod that holds the Knox Engine, passengers, and supplies, allowing you to travel back in time safely.

Time Capsule Bay: This is self-explanatory. The place at LRU where the time capsules are kept and the space-time continuum is monitored.

Paradox: A problem in time large enough to disrupt the flow of normal time and cause a tear/hole in time.

Tear in Time: The instant crack in time at the point where the paradox occurred. Manifests as a visual crack in the air with only black void beyond it.

Hole in Time: The next step after a tear; the resulting expanding void that ripples throughout space and then time, ripping time apart.



Appendix B: Random Background Tables

Random Age

d6	Age
1	Under 20
2	20s
3	30s
4	40s
5	50s
6	60s+

Random Occupations

d20	Occupation at LRU
1	Tenured Professor
2	Undergraduate Student
3	Graduate Student
4	Visiting Lecturer
5	IT Staff
6	Janitor
7	Security Guard
8	Administrative Staff
9	Librarian
10	Groundskeeper
11	Museum Curator
12	Professor
13	Lecturer
14	Research Assistant
15	Temporal Specialist
16	Lab Technician
17	Postdoctoral Researcher
18	Foreign Exchange Student
19	Media Archaeologist
20	That's Classified

Random Ambitions

d20	An Ambition They Have
1	To be loved
2	To be respected
3	To be feared
4	To be in-tune with nature
5	To win an international prize
6	To make their parents proud
7	To go against everything their parents wanted
8	To blaze a new trail
9	To follow established methods/paths
10	To discover themselves
11	To get through today, and then tomorrow
12	To stop and smell the roses
13	To speedrun every part of life
14	To be thoughtful
15	To be courageous/bold
16	To take control of their own destiny
17	To sit back and let someone else do the work
18	To understand the universe
19	To become famous
20	To defeat a childhood nemesis

Random Pet Peeves

d20	A Pet Peeve
1	Rule followers
2	Rule breakers
3	Flowers that smell bad
4	Beating around the bush, conversationally
5	Hedges that are trimmed into shapes
6	Especially blingy gemstones
7	When the paperclip is on the wrong way
8	Papercuts (they seem to happen oddly often)
9	Oblivious people
10	Inefficient paperwork and computer systems
11	Not stealing. Why don't more people steal?
12	True crime documentaries/shows
13	Self help books
14	Chairs that squeak when they're sitting in them
15	People telling them what to do
16	Cleanliness (they prefer a bit of mess)
17	Messiness (they'd like everything to be orderly)
18	Wind on an otherwise nice day
19	Keyboards that make a loud clicking sound
20	They're a little irked by everyone. Everyone.

Random Fun Fact

d20	A Pet Peeve
1	They used to skydive
2	They have more than five fish tanks
3	They weave flowers into their hair
4	They wear glasses, even though they don't need to
5	They once tried to fix a car and made it way worse
6	They're banned from a bar in their hometown
7	They spend a lot of time playing online slots
8	They've switched areas of study more than ten times
9	They kind of do wonder if the earth is flat
10	They are really into modern conspiracies
11	They have a bookcase full of books they still haven't read
12	They could swear they once saw sasquatch in the woods
13	They believe in aliens, at least a little
14	They're a citizen in three countries
15	They were the reason for a very specific rule at LRU (you choose)
16	They're always either a little bit late or very early
17	They once made genuine friends with a squirrel
18	They once wrote (and published) a very bad riddle book
19	They've always dreamed of playing a professional sport
20	They kind of think lizard people are real



Random Previous Jobs

d20	Job They Once Worked (or currently work)	d20	Job They Once Worked (or currently work)
1	Barista	11	Janitor
2	Carnival Worker	12	Paralegal
3	Bartender	13	Visiting Lecturer at LRU
4	Military	14	Student (have never worked)
5	Football Player	15	Engineer
6	Librarian	16	Software Developer
7	Teaching Assistant	17	Graphic Designer
8	Kindergarten Teacher	18	Set Builder in Theater
9	Nurse	19	Farmer
10	Receptionist	20	Private Detective

Appendix C: The Credits

This is the part where I get to say thank you! And I have some huge thank-yous to say, so buckle up.

Thank you to my Creative Technology & Design Capstone mentors and professors: Anthony Pinter, Danny Rankin, Tim Hutchings, and Michael Putlack.

Thank you to the many people who helped me playtest, let me run designs and mechanics by them, and listened to my many crazy ideas about Rewind: Katie Parks, Xilor Morin, Tessa Moskoff, Sophia, Mara Backsen, Elliot R, Milan C, Evie from the Future, John, Gavin, Felix A, Lyra R (there in spirit), Audra, Soren, Walker, and anyone else who helped but whose names I have forgotten to mention. I appreciate you all so, so much.

Thank you to my family, who also listened to my crazy ideas about Rewind (not always by choice)! Mom, Dad, Walker, Sugar, Spice, and the chickens.

And thank *you*, if you're reading this, for giving my little TTRPG a chance!



Name:		<i>Occupation/Position at LRU:</i>		Sturdy	Wounds 
<i>Pronouns:</i>		<i>Age:</i>			

Abilities <i>Brawn</i> <i>Agility</i> <i>Wits</i> <i>Charm</i> <i>Aware</i>	Eccentricities: <i>When you use an eccentricity to accomplish something, roll with advantage (roll 3d20 and take the lower roll).</i> Expertise: <i>When you use your expertise to accomplish something, roll with advantage (roll 3d20 and take the lower roll).</i> Gear:
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Background:	Notes:
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Character Sheet & Website Access

You may have noticed that, until now, you haven't seen the character sheet. Well, worry not! Here is is (to the left).

This is, however, a scaled-down version of the character sheet. Normally, it is 8.5" x 11". If you want a full-sized PDF of the character sheet (or of this book!) visit *rewindttrpg.app*. There, you can find the online resources you need to play this game, along with a full-size printable PDF character sheet.

Access the website here:

